



NEW STRATEGY: Raje
at swearing in ceremony

Preparing for the Polls

With an eye on the upcoming assembly polls, the chief minister expands her cabinet to accomodate castes and dissidents but will it work?

Call it the Modi effect. In Gujarat, while chief minister Narendra Modi was mending fences with dissident leaders shortly after his victory, Rajasthan Chief Minister Vasundhara Raje was following suit. She used a time-honoured tactic to please her detractors and broaden base—a Cabinet expansion and reshuffle of portfolios—with an eye on the assembly elections due next year. Gopinath Munde, the BJP man in-charge of Rajasthan, had rushed to Jaipur within hours of the Gujarat verdict to oversee the move and ensure that the timing was perfect. The expansion wasn't restricted to the cabinet, but involved parliamentary secretaries and chairpersons of boards and commissions too.

Raje did not ruffle too many feathers and the inductions show that in a state where caste is a crucial factor, it was a well thought out move. As a close aide of the chief minister told **INDIA TODAY**: "She preferred to take everyone along". Replace "everyone" with

"every caste" and her actions become clearer. Significantly, this was not Raje's original plan. Her initial instinct was to use expansion/reshuffle to punish dissidents and reward loyalists. However, when she approached party president L.K.Advani for permission, he gave her the go-ahead but cautioned her against projecting it as an act of vengeance. He repeated the advice when he flew in to Jaipur to address a rally on December 8 to commemorate her four years in power. Raje abided by his advice since he is one BJP leader she is close to (she was one of the few who had openly backed him when RSS attacked him following his utterances on Jinnah).

A major outcome of the expansion is that it has broadened caste representation and opened the door for dissidents to return to her fold. On December 8, she chose her biggest detractor in the cabinet Ghanshyam Tiwari to welcome her on the stage and, after the rally, went to the home

of another dissident minister and RSS favourite Madan Dilawar. Before the announcement of a cabinet reshuffle she had held a series of meetings with her close aides but finally took Advani's advice to accommodate divergent views and project herself as a consensus leader.

Her new-found political wisdom is best seen in her effort to address the ongoing power struggle between Gujjars and Meenas. Gujjars' demand for Scheduled Tribe (ST) status and Meenas' strong opposition to it reached another flashpoint with the Chopra Commission rejecting Gujjars' claim. Raje has now lobbed the ball in the Centre's court and has moved to placate Gujjars by promising quick development in their areas. She has removed Kirori Lal Meena and another minister

Virendra Meena, who were proving stumbling blocks, and elevated Nand Lal Meena who holds considerable influence over tribal Meenas in southern Rajasthan. Soon after taking the oath of office, new minister Ram Niwas Meena said he will respect ST status for Gujjars within a constitutional framework. Raje also inducted Nathu Singh Gujjar to keep the Gujar agitation from being hijacked by hardliners. The other two to be inducted are Kalicharan Saraf who represents Jaipur's business community and Surender Goyal who is from the potters' community.

Gambling on dissidents to cool down their opposition, Raje now has the political advantage of representing most castes, including Dalits in other appointments to preempt the emergence of the BSP. But Rajasthan is not Gujarat and Raje is no Modi. With Gujjars threatening another agitation from January 21, her latest political gambit could still come unstuck.

by Rohit Parihar

"This expansion to induct the less represented was due for long."

VASUNDHARA RAJE, CHIEF MINISTER